



Week 1 (May 19)

N.B.: This research journal is maintained by Asfi Hassan to document the progress, ideas, implementation, and findings arising from research conducted under the supervision of Dr. Ahmed Biniaz at the University of Windsor as part of the NSERC Undergraduate Student Research Award (USRA). This project investigates a computational geometry approach to a problem closely related to the Lonely Runner Problem, a well-known open problem in number theory and discrete mathematics. The purpose of this journal is to provide a clear and organized record of my work throughout the Summer 2026 research term. It is intended to document my understanding, progress, and software development rather than to claim original authorship of all ideas presented. Many of the mathematical concepts and techniques discussed are drawn from existing research and are included to support my learning and to show how they inform my investigations and implementations. Entries may include mathematical observations, algorithmic developments, software design and implementation details, computational experiments, visualizations, meeting notes, and reflections on challenges encountered during the project. This journal serves as a comprehensive record of both the research process and the software tools developed to better understand this problem. Artificial intelligence tools were used to assist in understanding advanced mathematical concepts and research papers, and to support the preparation and refinement of this research journal at an undergraduate computer science level.

Foundational Understanding of the Lonely Runner Problem

Review of Related Literature

The Lonely Runner Conjecture (LRC) is a well-known problem in number theory and combinatorics involving runners moving at distinct constant speeds around a unit circle. The conjecture states that for any set of $n + 1$ runners, each runner will eventually be at least $\frac{1}{n+1}$ units away from every other runner along the circle. By fixing one runner at speed 0, the problem reduces to finding a time t such that the minimum circular distance between the stationary runner and all moving runners is at least $\frac{1}{n+1}$. In this project, the problem is interpreted geometrically by plotting time on the x-axis and the corresponding distance function on the y-axis, producing periodic piecewise-linear graphs whose peaks are farthest from the stationary runner. This transformation converts an abstract modular arithmetic problem into a visual and computational geometry problem. The resulting graphs reveal repeating patterns and critical points where the minimum distance function reaches local maxima. These visual structures make it easier to identify candidate witness times and compare the behavior of different speed sets.

Several key papers guided this research. Ram Krishna Pandey proved the conjecture for lacunary speed sets using a constructive interval-based argument, while recent works by Matthieu Rosenfeld and by Touch Sungkawichai and Tanupat Trakulthongchai used computer-assisted methods to verify the conjecture for up to thirteen total runners. These papers show that the problem can be reduced to a finite search over integer speed sets using modular sieves, bounded reductions, and exhaustive computation. Additional recent preprints refine these techniques by combining modular arithmetic, combinatorial reasoning, and algorithmic filtering to eliminate large classes of potential counterexamples. Inspired by these ideas, this project develops an interactive Python framework using Tkinter and Matplotlib to visualize the distance functions and explore the algorithmic structure underlying one of the most significant open problems in modern combinatorics and number theory.

Problem Sketch from Week 1

During the first meeting in week 1 of the research term, I studied a series of introductory sketches provided by my supervisor, Dr. Ahmed Biniiaz, where he explained the core ideas behind the Lonely Runner Problem and several related concepts. These sketches used the unit circle to illustrate how runners move at different constant speeds and showed that a runner is considered lonely when they are at least $1/(k+1)$ units away from every other runner, where $k+1$ is the total number of runners. By fixing one runner with speed 0, the problem becomes easier to analyze geometrically, since the distance between a moving runner and the stationary runner increases up to a maximum of $1/2$ of the unit circle and then decreases symmetrically. This geometric interpretation provides an intuitive way to visualize the problem and forms the basis for representing and studying it using computational geometry techniques within a plane.

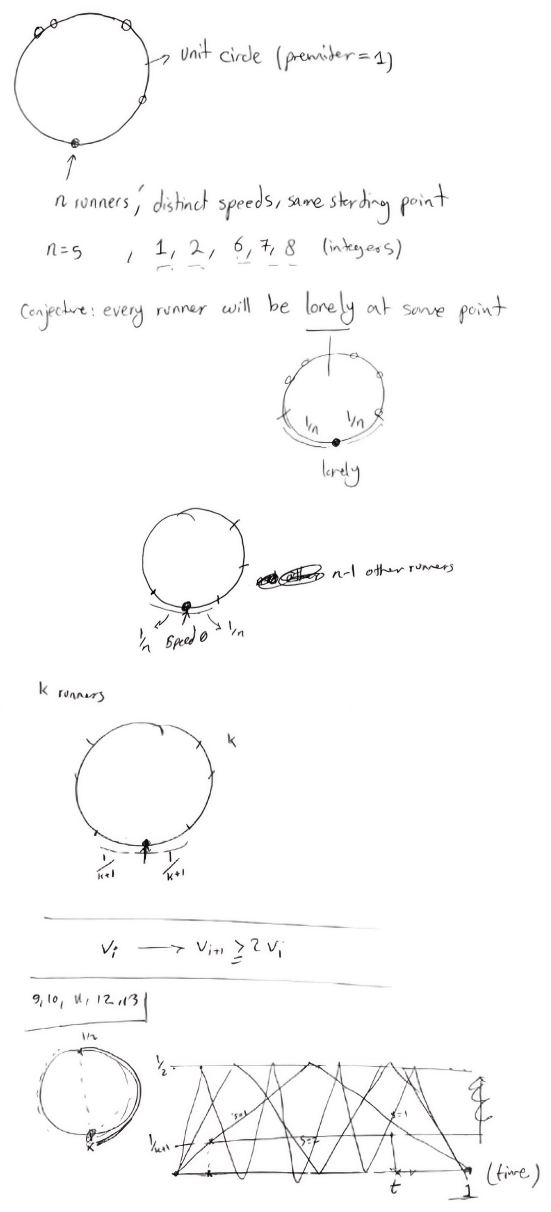


Figure 1: Introductory sketches illustrating the unit circle and graphical interpretation of the Lonely Runner Problem. Sketches provided by Dr. Ahmed Biniiaz.

Current Software Implementation

To support the geometric interpretation of the Lonely Runner Conjecture, an initial Python prototype was developed using the `Tkinter` and `Matplotlib` libraries. `Tkinter` is used to create a graphical user interface (GUI), while `Matplotlib` is used to generate and display mathematical plots directly within the application window. The program launches in full-screen mode and provides two input fields: one for the number of speeds, denoted by n , and another for the corresponding integer velocity values entered as a space-separated list.

The core functionality is implemented in the `draw()` function. After validating the user input, the program iterates through each velocity v and computes a sequence of equally spaced isosceles triangles over the interval $[0, 1]$. Each triangle has base length $\frac{1}{v}$ and height $\frac{1}{2}$, representing one period of the distance-to-nearest-integer function associated with that speed. Since the function $\|tv\|$ is periodic and piecewise linear, the repeated triangles provide an exact geometric representation of the runner's relative distance from the stationary runner over time. Different colors are assigned to distinguish the graphs corresponding to different speeds.

The application also includes a `reset()` function, which clears all input fields and removes the current plot, allowing new speed sets to be entered efficiently. The plotting area is embedded directly into the GUI using `FigureCanvasTkAgg`, and the aspect ratio is fixed so that all triangles retain their correct geometric proportions. This prototype establishes the foundational visualization framework for the project and serves as the basis for future extensions, including the computation of intersection points, automatic identification of candidate loneliness times, and algorithmic verification of specific speed configurations.

The core plotting algorithm iterates through each input velocity v and constructs its corresponding distance function. For each speed, the interval $[0, 1]$ is divided into v equal subintervals of length $\frac{1}{v}$. In each subinterval, the program computes the left endpoint, right endpoint, and midpoint, then draws an isosceles triangle of height $\frac{1}{2}$. Each triangle represents one period of the distance-to-nearest-integer function $\|tv\|$. Repeating this process over all subintervals produces the full piecewise-linear graph for that runner, with distinct colors used to differentiate multiple speeds. The code snippet is provided as a figure below:

```
for idx, v in enumerate(values):
    color = colors[idx % len(colors)]
    triangle_base = line_length / v

    for i in range(v):
        base_left_x = i * triangle_base
        base_right_x = (i + 1) * triangle_base
        top_vertex_x = (base_left_x + base_right_x) / 2

        ax.plot(
            [base_left_x, base_right_x, top_vertex_x, base_left_x],
            [0, 0, y, 0],
            color=color
        )
```

Figure 2: Core algorithm above used to generate the triangular representation of the conjecture.

Week 2 (May 26)

Review and Examination of Various Cases

During this weeks discussions with Dr. Ahmed Biniiaz, we examined why the Lonely Runner Conjecture becomes significantly more difficult as the number of runners increases. In particular, we discussed the complexity of modern sieving techniques, which use filtering methods to eliminate impossible speed configurations during large computational searches. I was told to take a deeper read into *The Lonely Runner Conjecture turns 60*, to become familiar with concepts. Several special cases of the conjecture were also suggested for independent study and proof attempts, including weaker loneliness bounds and restricted families of runner speeds.

Case 1 — Proving the Weaker Bound $\frac{1}{2k}$

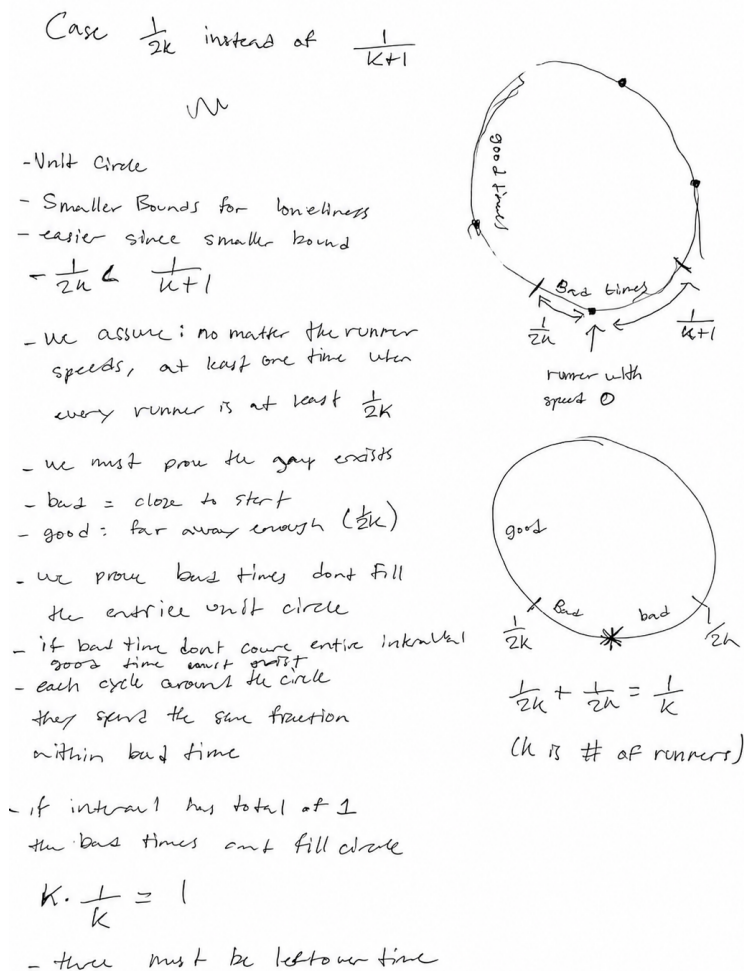


Figure 3: Illustration of the good and bad regions on the unit circle for the $1/(2k)$ loneliness bound and brainstorming proof for Case 1.

This proof establishes a weaker version of the Lonely Runner Conjecture by showing that there exists a time t such that every runner is at least $\frac{1}{2k}$ away from the starting point. Here, k represents the number of moving runners, and the runner speeds are denoted by $v_1, v_2, \dots, v_k$.

For each runner v_i , define the set of “bad times” as

$$A_i = \left\{ t \in (0, 1) : \|tv_i\| < \frac{1}{2k} \right\}.$$

The idea of “bad times” is simple: these are the times when a runner is still too close to the starting point, meaning the runner is not yet lonely. We create a set A_i to collect all of these bad times together for runner i . The notation $t \in (0, 1)$ means we only examine times between 0 and 1, since the runners move periodically around the unit circle and their positions repeat after one full cycle.

In this expression, t represents time, v_i is the speed of the i -th runner, and $\|tv_i\|$ represents the distance from the runner to the nearest integer position on the unit circle, which corresponds to the distance from the starting point. The condition

$$\|tv_i\| < \frac{1}{2k}$$

therefore means that runner i is closer than $\frac{1}{2k}$ to the starting point, making that time “bad.”

For a single runner, the total amount of bad time is less than $\frac{1}{k}$. Since there are k runners, the total amount of bad time across all runners is still less than the entire interval $(0, 1)$. Therefore, there must exist at least one time t which is not contained in any bad set A_i . At this time,

$$\|tv_i\| \geq \frac{1}{2k}$$

for every runner i . Hence, every runner is sufficiently far from the starting point simultaneously.

Weaker Bound $\frac{1}{2k}$, when $k = 4$

To understand the idea, consider 4 runners. In this case, each runner is considered “bad” when they are within $\frac{1}{8}$ of the starting point. Each runner is only bad for approximately one quarter of the time. At first glance, four runners each contributing one quarter of the interval appears to cover the entire timeline. However, many of these bad intervals overlap, meaning the same moments are counted multiple times. As a result, the bad times cannot cover the entire interval $(0, 1)$. Therefore, there must exist at least one time where none of the runners are bad, implying that all four runners are simultaneously at least $\frac{1}{8}$ away from the starting point.

This does not prove the full Lonely Runner Conjecture, which requires a distance of $\frac{1}{k+1}$, but it does establish the existence of a guaranteed weaker loneliness distance of $\frac{1}{2k}$.

Reference: Guillem Perarnau and Oriol Serra, *The Lonely Runner Conjecture turns 60*, Section 5: “Gap of loneliness.” The weaker bound $\kappa(n) \geq \frac{1}{2n}$ is attributed to Wills.

Case 2 — Speeds Growing by a Factor of Two

This case proves the Lonely Runner Conjecture when the runner speeds increase rapidly. Specifically, the speeds satisfy

$$v_{i+1} \geq 2v_i.$$

This means each runner moves at least twice as fast as the previous runner. For example, possible speeds could be 1, 2, 4, 8, 16. Such sequences are known as lacunary sequences.

The condition $v_{i+1} \geq 2v_i$ is what makes the proof work. Since each runner is moving at least twice as fast as the previous runner, the corresponding distance function repeats more frequently over the interval $[0, 1]$. Intuitively, this creates many opportunities to find times where additional runners satisfy the loneliness condition without eliminating all previously valid times.

The goal is to show that there exists a time t where every runner is at least

$$\frac{1}{k+1}$$

away from the starting point, where k is the number of moving runners.

The proof works by constructing nested intervals of valid times. An interval is simply a continuous range of times. For example, the interval $[0.2, 0.4]$ contains every time between 0.2 and 0.4. The notation $I_2 \subseteq I_1$ means that I_2 is completely contained inside I_1 .

First, an interval I_1 is chosen where the first runner is sufficiently far from the starting point. Then a smaller interval $I_2 \subseteq I_1$ is selected where both the first and second runners satisfy the loneliness condition. This process continues:

$$I_1 \supset I_2 \supset I_3 \supset \cdots \supset I_k.$$

Because each speed is at least twice as large as the previous one, the distance patterns repeat more frequently, creating enough opportunities to continue choosing smaller valid intervals. Since every interval is contained in the previous one, any time remaining in the final interval automatically works for all runners considered so far.

At the end of the construction, the final interval I_k is still nonempty, meaning it contains at least one valid time t . Therefore,

$$\|tv_i\| \geq \frac{1}{k+1}$$

for every runner i , and all runners become lonely simultaneously.

Reference: Ram Krishna Pandey, *A Note on the Lonely Runner Conjecture*. Also summarized in Guillem Perarnau and Oriol Serra, *The Lonely Runner Conjecture turns 60*, Section 7.3: “Lacunary sequences.”

Case 3 — When $\frac{v_k}{v_1} \leq k$

This case proves the Lonely Runner Conjecture when the fastest runner is not excessively faster than the slowest runner. The condition is

$$\frac{v_k}{v_1} \leq k,$$

where v_1 is the smallest speed, v_k is the largest speed, and k is the number of moving runners. Equivalently,

$$v_k \leq kv_1.$$

This means the fastest runner is at most k times faster than the slowest runner.

The proof begins by defining

$$N = v_1 + v_k.$$

Here, N is simply the sum of the smallest and largest speeds. Under the assumption above, all runner speeds lie inside a controlled interval between

$$\frac{N}{k+1} \quad \text{and} \quad N - \frac{N}{k+1}.$$

This guarantees that the runner speeds are not too small and not too close to N . Because of this bounded structure, there exists a time t such that

$$\|tv_i\| \geq \frac{1}{k+1}$$

for every runner i .

In simple terms, when the speeds are relatively close together, the runners' periodic distance patterns behave in a more controlled way, making the conjecture easier to prove.

Reference: Guillem Perarnau and Oriol Serra, *The Lonely Runner Conjecture turns 60*, Section 7.1: “Simple remarks and further reductions.”

References

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